The Best Christmas Pageant Ever (Play)

By Barbara Robinson

BETH: **(Pg 1-3)** The Herdmans were the worst kids in the whole history of the world. They lied and stole and cussed their teachers and took the name of the Lord in vain. There were six of them - Ralph, Imogene, Leroy, Claude, Ollie and Gladys - and they went through the Woodrow Wilson school like those South American fish that strip your bones clean . . . Stealing things and whamming kids . . . it was hard to get away from them. There was only one safe place.

CHARLIE: *(offstage, singing happily and at a fast upbeat pace)* Sweet hour of prayer, sweet hour of prayer, Because there are no Herdmans there. And Jesus loves us, as they say, Because he keeps them miles away. *

BETH: That's my little brother, Charlie.

MOTHER: It's a very practical sentiment. Charlie was black and blue all last year because he had to sit next to Leroy Herdman in school.

FATHER: Is he the worst one? Leroy?

CHARLIE. They're all the worst one. Gladys isn't big, but she's fast, and she's mean, and she bites. Stay away from them. Go to church.

MOTHER: I'm glad to hear you feel that way. No arguments this year about the Christmas pageant.

CHARLIE. I don't want to be *in* it! Nobody wants to be *in* it!

BETH: **(Pg 5)** Our Christmas pageant isn't what you'd call four-star entertainment. It's always the same old Christmas story with the same old Mary and Joseph . . . The Herdmans . . . That was Charlie's fault.

INTRODUCTION

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CHARLIE: (Pg 8-9) Hey, Leroy, you give me back my lunch!

LEROY: Sure, kid, here. *(hands him a lunch bag)*

CHARLIE: *(looks inside)* You stole my dessert again! You know what? I don't care if you steal my dessert. I get all the dessert I want in Sunday school.

LEROY: *(interested in this)* Oh, yeah? What kind of dessert?

CHARLIE: All kinds. Chocolate cake and candy bars and cookies . . .

LEROY: You're a liar.

CHARLIE: . . . and ice cream, and doughnuts and cupcakes!

LEROY: *(pause)* ... Sunday school, huh?

NARRATOR: That was the wrong thing to tell Herdmans . . . and, sure enough, the very next Sunday there they were in Sunday school, just in time to hear about the Christmas pageant...

MOTHER: Today we're going to decide who will play the main roles in our Christmas pageant. **(Pg 11-12)** Now I want you to think about Mary . . . She was quiet and gentle and kind. The girl who plays Mary should be that kind of person. Who would like to volunteer for that part? *(Imogene raises her hand)* Did you have a question, Imogene?

IMOGENE: No, I want to be Mary . . . and Ralph, over there, he wants to be Joseph.

MOTHER: *(taken aback)* Oh. Well . . . I'll just make a list of volunteers and then we'll all decide who it should be. Now, who else would like to be Joseph? Raise your hands . . . please . . . any volunteers . . . *(silence)* Very well. Ralph Herdman will be our Joseph. Imogene has volunteered to be . . . *(tiny break here, as if she can hardly bear to connect Imogene with Mary)* . . . Mary. Janet? . . . Roberta? . . . . Alice? *(silence)*

GLADYS: What's left?

MOTHER: *(reluctantly)* The Angel of the Lord . . .

GLADYS: I'll be that. What is it?

MOTHER: (Pg 18-19) *(Quoting scripture)* And lo, the Angel of the Lord came upon them, and the Glory of

GLADYS: *(Flinging her arms out)* Shazam! . . . Out of the black night, with horrible vengeance,

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the Mighty Marvo . . .

MOTHER: This is the Angel of the Lord, who comes to the shepherds . . .

GLADYS: Out of nowhere, right? In the black night, right? Shazam**!**

ELMER: **(Pg 13)** *(raising his hand)* I don't want to be a shepherd . . . Gladys Herdman hits too hard!

******** (phone conversations) *********

MRS. SLOCUM: **(Pg 14-15)** Vera? Irma Slocum. I just heard that Imogene Herdman is going to be Mary in the Christmas pageant, and I ... all six of them?

MRS. ARMSTRONG. Imogene Herdman! ... What kind of a child is that to be Mary the Mother of Jesus? If I'd been around this never would have happened!

MRS. SLOCUM: . . . better nail down the church and lock up the silver service and hide the collection plates before they clean them out . . .

****

MOTHER: *(mimicking Mrs. Armstrong)* "If I'd been around, this never would have happened!" I'm going to make this the best Christmas pageant ever, and I'm going to do it ***with*** the Herdmans! After all, they raised their hands and nobody else did . . .

******** (pageant practice) ********

MOTHER: **(Pg 24-25)** . . . Music . . . . Shepherds . . . Music . . . Wise Men! *(3 Herdmans slouch aimlessly down the aisle and up to the manger)*

IMOGENE: **(Pg 19)** Well, it's about time somebody important showed up! If they're kings, they can get the baby out of the barn, and tell the innkeeper where to get off!

MOTHER: *(ignoring this turn of plot)* ... They were sent by Herod, who was ... well, he was the ***main*** king, and he wanted to find Jesus and have him put to death.

IMOGENE: My God! He just got born! They're gonna **kill** a baby?

MOTHER: Herod isn't in the play.

LEROY: He's out to kill the baby, and he isn't even in the play?

CLAUDE: **(Pg 20)** *(warming to this scenario)* No . . . I know ... Joseph gets the shepherds together and they go wipe out Herod! *(He makes a machine gun gesture.)*

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IMOGENE: And I run away with the baby till the fight's over!

RALPH: Somebody ought to fix the innkeeper . . . Gladys, you wipe out the innkeeper!

GLADYS: **(Pg 21)** *(happily)* Yeh! ... Zap!

OLLIE: What's the name of this play?

GLADYS: I know a name! . . . I know a name! I'd call it . . . Revenge at Bethlehem!

BETH: Revenge at Bethlehem! The Herdmans thought the Christmas story came right out of the F.B.I. files! At least they picked out the right villain- it was Herod they wanted to gang up on and not the baby Jesus. *(As the Wisemen approach IMOGENE holds up the doll by the back of the neck, waving it in the air.)*

IMOGENE: **(Pg 25**) I've got the baby here . . . don't touch him! I named him Jesus!

MOTHER: *(hurrying on stage)* No, no, no! You don't say ... *(nerves fraying away)* ... anything! Mary doesn't say anything. No one says anything! Mary and Joseph make a lovely picture for us to look at while we think about Christmas and what it means! ... Now, put the doll back.

IMOGENE: *(disgruntled)* I don't get to say anything . . . some angel tells me what to call the baby . . . I would have named him Bill.

GLADYS: **(Pg 26)** *(yells at the Shepherds)* Unto you [Bill] is born!

IMOGENE: Unto ***me!*** Not them, me! I'm the one that had the baby!

RALPH: **(Pg 17)** *(Not so much trying to shock, as he is pleased to understand something.)* Pregnant! She was pregnant! *(There is much giggling and tittering.)*

ALICE: It's better to say 'great with child'. I'm not supposed to talk about people being pregnant, especially in church.

******** Scene ********

REV. HOPKINS: **(Pg 28-29)** The whole church is in an uproar. Jesus said, "Suffer the little children to come unto me", but I'm not sure he meant the Herdmans . . . Don't you think we should cancel the pageant? Every one seems ***to*** think it's going to be a . . . a . . .

MOTHER: Disaster? *(Obviously, that's the word he had in mind.)* Well, they're wrong! ... It's going to be the best Christmas pageant we ever had!

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REV. HOPKINS: But . . . I don't think anyone will come to see it!

BETH: I didn't think so, either, and neither did Charlie . . . but we were wrong. On Christmas Eve the church was jammed full. Everybody came . . . to see what the Herdmans would do.

******* (the night of the pageant) *******

MOTHER: Oh, I don't have any idea what's going to happen tonight! We've never once gone through the whole thing, and the Herdmans still think it's some kind of spy story. It may be the first Christmas pageant in history where Joseph and the Wise Men get in a fight and Mary runs away with the baby.

BETH: **(Pg 30)** It's just going to be awful, you know. They look like trick or treat- all dirty and fastened together with safety pins and wearing their mouldy old sneakers . . . Mary and Joseph, I mean. They look like refugees or something.

FATHER: Well . . . that's what they were . . . Mary and Joseph. They ***were*** refugees, in a way. They were a long way from home, didn't have any place to stay, didn't know anybody. They were probably cold and hungry and tired . . . and messy. *(Beth is struck by the sense of this new idea)*

****** Cut to the actual performance already in progress *******

MAXINE: **(Pg 33-36)** *(Narrating)* . . . And in that region, there were shepherds in the field, keeping watch over their flocks by night. And an Angel of the Lord appears to them and said . . . *(Gladys roars on stage with her message)*

GLADYS: Hey! Hey! Unto you a child is born! . . . It's Jesus, and he's in the barn . . . Go see him! *(the Shepherds hesitate)* Go on , he's over there . . . Go on!

MAXINE: There came Wise Men from the East to worship him.

LEROY: *(singing)* We Three Kings of Orient Are . . .

ALICE: They look awful, too. And what's that Leroy's got?

BETH: *(craning her neck to see)* It's . . . it's a ham!

ALICE: Bet they stole it!

BETH: No . . . I think it's the ham from their welfare basket. It's the only thing they ever gave away in their whole life.

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MAXINE: The Wise Men and the Sheperds departed, praising God for all they had seen and heard. But Mary kept all these things and pondered them in her heart. *(Imogene takes the doll from the manger and holds it. She puts it up on her shoulder, as if to burp it. She is crying)*

ALICE: *(in reverent awe)* Look . . . Mary's crying.

******** After the pageant *******

MRS. MCCARTHY: Could you believe that was Imogene Herdman? And all the rest of them? This was the best Christmas pageant we ever had, and I'm not sure why, but I think it was them. There was just something . . . different.

MRS. SLOCUM: Well, the Angel of the Lord was different!

MRS. MCCARTHY: Yes, but you know, I liked that! Had lots of spirit. Sometimes you can't even hear the Angel of the Lord.

MRS. SLOCUM: Well... it did seem . . . ***real***. *(They exit.)*

BETH: It did seem real, as if it might have happened just that way. We all thought the pageant was about Jesus, but that was only part of it. It was about a new baby, and his mother and father who were in a whole lot of trouble - no money, no place to go, nobody they knew. Because of the Herdmans, it was a whole new story - Imogene, burping the baby, and the Wise Men bringing such a sensible present. After all, they couldn't eat frankincense! And even Gladys-"He's in the barn. Go see him" But I guess it wasn't like that for Imogene. For her, the Christmas pageant turned out to be all wonder and mystery, as if she just caught on to what Christmas was all about.

GLADYS: **(Pg 38)** *(offstage)* Heyl . . . *(She runs on stage and points at the audience.)* Hey, unto you a child is born!

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AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
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Sweet Hour of Prayer – Music and Lyrics for inspiration can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yz5pD6C9h-w

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